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Biologists with a predilection for theory have tried—and largely failed—to define what it is that makes something a living thing. Organisms take in energy-providing materials and excrete waste products, but so do automobiles. Living things replicate and take part in evolution, but so do some computer programs. We must be open to the possibility that there are living things on other planets. Therefore, we will not be successful in defining what it is that makes something a living thing merely by examining living things on Earth—the only ones we know. Trying to do so is analogous to trying to specify _____.

Which of the following most logically completes the passage?

A. the laws of physics by using pure mathematics

B. what a fish is by listing its chemical components

C. what an animal is by examining a plant

D. what a machine is by examining a sketch of it

E. what a mammal is by examining a zebra

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Some biologists have tried, unsuccessfully, to find a theoretically defensible account of what it means for something to be a living thing. Some of the suggested definitions are too broad because they include things that we would not regard as living. To find life on other planets, we must not narrow our conception of life by basing it simply on the kinds of life encountered on Earth.

**Reasoning** *Which of the answer choices would be the logically most appropriate completion of the argument?* The argument points out that life-forms elsewhere in the universe may be very different from any of the life-forms on Earth. Both life-forms on Earth and life-forms discovered elsewhere would all qualify as members of a very large class, the class of all life-forms. Taking life-forms on Earth, a mere subset of the class of all life-forms, as representative of all life-forms would be a logical mistake and might not lead to success in defining what it means for something to be a living thing. The correct answer choice, therefore, would involve a case of specifying what some general class of things is by examining the members of only a small, and not necessarily representative, subset of that class of things. In other words, the correct answer choice will involve the logical mistake of taking a subset as representative of a larger class.

A. Pure mathematics is not a subset of the law of physics, so this does not involve the logical mistake of taking a subset as representative of a larger class.

B. The chemical components of a fish are what make up the fish; they are not a small subset of the fish, so this does not involve the logical mistake of taking a subset as representative of a larger class.

C. Plants are not a subset of the class of animals, so this does not involve the logical mistake of taking a subset as representative of a larger class.

D. A sketch of a machine is not a subclass of the machine itself, so this does not involve the logical mistake of taking a subset as representative of a larger class.

E. **Correct.** This involves the logical mistake of taking the class of zebras, a subclass of the class of mammals, as representative of the class of all mammals. Logically, it resembles taking the class of life-forms on Earth as representative of the class of all life-forms.

**The correct answer is E.**

•

For the period from the eighth century through the eleventh century, the shifting boundaries between Kingdom F and Kingdom G have not been well charted. Although a certain village in a border region between the two kingdoms usually belonged to Kingdom G, ninth-century artifacts found in the village were in the typical Kingdom F style of that time. It is unclear whether the village was actually a part of Kingdom F in the ninth century or whether it was a part of Kingdom G but had merely adopted Kingdom F's artistic styles under Kingdom F's cultural influence.

Which of the following would, if found in ninth-century sites in the village, best help in determining whether the village was a part of Kingdom F or Kingdom G in the ninth century?

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village was a part of Kingdom F or Kingdom G in the ninth century?

A. A trading contract written in the Kingdom G dialect

B. A drawing of a dwelling complex known to have existed on the border of Kingdom F and Kingdom G in the ninth century

C. Knives and other utensils made from metal typical of ninth-century mining sites in Kingdom F

D. Some fragments of pottery made in the Kingdom G style from the seventh century out of materials only found in Kingdom F

E. Numerous teeth from the ninth century with a chemical signature typical only of teeth from people who had grown up in the heart of Kingdom F

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** From the eighth century to the eleventh century, the boundaries between two kingdoms, F and G, shifted, but these shifts are not well documented. A certain village in a border region was usually part of Kingdom G, but ninth-century artifacts in the village are typical of the style of ninth-century artifacts from Kingdom F.

**Reasoning** *What evidence, if it were found in the ninth-century sites in the village, would be most helpful in determining which of the two kingdoms the village was a part of during that century?* Information strongly indicating that during the ninth century the village was primarily settled by people clearly from Kingdom F would lend support to the claim that the village was part of Kingdom F in the ninth century.

A. A trading contract found at a ninth-century site in the village written in Kingdom G dialect would not settle whether the village was part of Kingdom G, because it could be the case that such a document would be written in that dialect even if the village were part of Kingdom F but regularly traded with Kingdom G.

B. Finding at a ninth-century site in the village a drawing of a dwelling complex known to have been on the border of Kingdom F and Kingdom G would not be useful in determining to which kingdom the village belonged at the time. We are not told in which kingdom that dwelling complex existed, and even if we were told, it could be that a villager in the other kingdom had a drawing of that complex for some reason (e.g., the villager could have had it because that complex was going to be attacked in a skirmish between the kingdoms).

C. Because there could have been trade between Kingdom F and Kingdom G, the fact that utensils made from metal typical of ninth-century mining sites in Kingdom F would not be very helpful in determining to which of the two kingdoms the village belonged in that century.

D. If fragments of pottery from the seventh century made in the Kingdom G style but from materials found only in Kingdom F were discovered, it would be unclear in which kingdom the pottery had been made. Given that the fragments may be from two centuries earlier than the period in question, and that we do not even know what kingdom the pottery was created in, these fragments would be of no use in determining to which kingdom the village belonged in the ninth century.

E. **Correct.** Although the mere presence of people from Kingdom F in the village would not provide strong support for the claim that the village was part of Kingdom F during the ninth century—the village could have shifted from Kingdom F to Kingdom G while maintaining much of its Kingdom F population—the presence of significant numbers of people from the heart of Kingdom F would support the claim that there was widespread migration of people from Kingdom F to the village. This is what one might reasonably expect if the village was part of Kingdom F during the ninth century. The discovery of numerous teeth that clearly belonged to people who grew up in the heart of Kingdom F in the ninth century would support the claim that many such people lived in the village during that century.

**The correct answer is E.**

•

Sammy: For my arthritis, I am going to try my aunt's diet: large amounts of wheat germ and garlic. She was able to move more easily right after she started that diet.

Pat: When my brother began that diet, his arthritis got worse. But he has been doing much better since he stopped eating vegetables in the nightshade family, such as tomatoes and peppers.

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Which of the following, if true, would provide a basis for explaining the fact that Sammy's aunt and Pat's brother had contrasting experiences with the same diet?

A. A change in diet, regardless of the nature of the change, frequently brings temporary relief from arthritis symptoms.

B. The compounds in garlic that can lessen the symptoms of arthritis are also present in tomatoes and peppers.

C. Arthritis is a chronic condition whose symptoms improve and worsen from time to time without regard to diet.

D. In general, men are more likely to have their arthritis symptoms alleviated by avoiding vegetables in the nightshade family than are women.

E. People who are closely related are more likely to experience the same result from adopting a particular diet than are people who are unrelated.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** Sammy's aunt's arthritis apparently improved after she consumed large amounts of wheat germ and garlic. Pat's brother's arthritis deteriorated after he followed the same diet. Since he stopped eating vegetables in the nightshade family, such as tomatoes and peppers, his arthritis has improved.

**Reasoning** *What could account for the fact that Sammy's aunt's arthritis improved and Pat's brother's arthritis got worse after they both followed the wheat germ and garlic diet?* The fact that a person has a health improvement following a diet is, by itself, very weak evidence for the claim that the diet caused the improvement. More generally, the fact that one event follows another is seldom, by itself, evidence that the earlier event caused the later. This applies to both the experience of Sammy's aunt and that of Pat's brother with the wheat germ and garlic diet.

A. In theory, this could be somewhat relevant to Sammy's aunt's experience but not to Pat's brother's experience. It is, however, insufficient to explain either.

B. Even if this is true, it might be the case that a large quantity of the compounds in question must be consumed in concentrated form to benefit arthritis. No evidence is given to indicate whether this is so. Regardless, the puzzle as to why the wheat germ and garlic diet was followed by arthritis improvement in one case and not in the other remains.

C. **Correct.** If we know there are typically fluctuations in the severity of arthritis symptoms and these can occur independent of diet, then the divergent experiences of the two people can be attributed to such fluctuations—even if it is conceded that some diets can affect arthritis symptoms in some manner. The wheat germ and garlic diet may, or may not, be such a diet.

D. This could throw light on Pat's brother's experience but not on Sammy's aunt's experience.

E. If this is correct, it is still far too general to provide a basis for explaining why the experiences of the two people were different. Does it apply to arthritis? We're not told. Nor are we told that it applies to the wheat germ and garlic diet. Is Pat's brother closely related to Sammy's aunt? We don't know.

**The correct answer is C.**

•

In the 1960s, surveys of Florida's alligator population indicated that the population was dwindling rapidly. Hunting alligators was banned. By the early 1990s, the alligator population had recovered, and restricted hunting was allowed. Over the course of the 1990s, reports of alligators appearing on golf courses and lawns increased dramatically. Therefore, in spite of whatever alligator hunting went on, the alligator population must have increased significantly over the decade of the 1990s.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously weakens the argument?

A. The human population of Florida increased significantly during the 1990s.

B. The hunting restrictions applied to commercial as well as private hunters.

C. The number of sightings of alligators in lakes and swamps increased greatly in Florida during the 1990s.

D. Throughout the 1990s, selling alligator products was more strictly regulated than hunting was.

E. Most of the sightings of alligators on golf courses and lawns in the 1990s occurred at times at which few people

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E. Most of the sightings of alligators on golf courses and lawns in the 1990s occurred at times at which few people were present on those golf courses and lawns.

**Argument Evaluation**

**Situation** In the 1960s, hunting alligators was banned in Florida to allow the alligator population to recover—as it did by the early 1990s. Then restricted hunting was allowed. But over the decade, reports of alligators appearing on golf courses and lawns increased greatly. The author of the argument concludes from this information that the alligator population must have increased significantly during the 1990s.

**Reasoning** *What new piece of information would seriously weaken the argument?* Increased sightings of alligators could occur either because there are more alligators or because more people are seeing the ones that are there. Any information indicating an increase in the ratio of people to alligators in locations where the two species coexist could offer an alternative to the hypothesis that the alligator population increased.

A. **Correct.** The argument suggests that Florida is an area in which golf courses and lawns are common. A large rapid increase in the human population of such an area would probably lead to a significant increase in the number of golf courses and lawns, some of which would encroach on the alligators' habitats. Even without any increase in the overall number of alligators, this could lead to an increase in both the percentage of alligators that venture onto golf courses and lawns and the number of people who happen to be in such locations when alligators are present.

B. This information is peripheral to the issue we are being asked to address; it neither weakens nor strengthens the argument.

C. This information tends to strengthen, not weaken, the argument; it suggests that the frequency of reported sightings in other places was reliable and that the sightings indicated a surge in the alligator population.

D. To the extent that this is relevant, it could provide some weak support for the argument. Strictly regulating the sale of alligator products could deter alligator hunting by making it less profitable and could thus allow further increases in the alligator population.

E. Without further evidence, the net effect of this information cannot be reliably determined. On the one hand, if *sightings* is understood as elliptical for *reports of seeing alligators*, this could suggest that some of the reports may be dubious because they are not corroborated by additional observers. On the other hand, it suggests that the alligator population may in fact have increased. Times when few people are present are also times when wildlife such as alligators would be more likely to venture onto lawns and golf courses. Without any evidence that sightings before the 1990s did not typically occur in such conditions, this suggests that the number of alligators observable at those times increased in the 1990s.

**The correct answer is A.**

•

Infotek, a computer manufacturer in Katrovia, has just introduced a new personal computer model that sells for significantly less than any other model. Market research shows, however, that very few Katrovian households without personal computers would buy a computer, regardless of its price. Therefore, introducing the new model is unlikely to increase the number of computers in Katrovian homes.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument depends?

A. Infotek achieved the lower price of the new model by using components of lower quality than those used by other manufacturers.

B. The main reason cited by consumers in Katrovia for replacing a personal computer is the desire to have an improved model.

C. Katrovians in households that already have computers are unlikely to purchase the new Infotek model as an additional computer for home use.

D. The price of other personal computers in Katrovia is unlikely to drop below the price of Infotek's new model in the near future.

E. Most personal computers purchased in Katrovia are intended for home use.

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**Argument Construction**

**Situation** In Katrovia, a new personal computer model costs less than any other model. But market research shows that very few Katrovian households without personal computers would buy even cheap ones.

**Reasoning** *What must be true in order for the stated facts to support the conclusion that introducing the new computer model is unlikely to increase the overall number of computers in Katrovian homes?* The market research supports the conclusion that no new computer model is likely to significantly increase the number of computers in Katrovian homes that currently lack computers. But the overall number of computers in Katrovian homes will still increase if Katrovian homes that already have computers buy additional computers while keeping their existing ones. So, the argument has to assume that the new computer model will not increase the number of additional computers purchased for Katrovian homes that already have computers.

A. Even if Infotek used high-quality components in the new computer model, Katrovians might still refuse to buy it.

B. Replacing a personal computer does not change the overall number of personal computers in homes, so Katrovians' motives for replacing their computers are irrelevant to the argument.

C. **Correct.** As explained above, unless computers of the new model are purchased as additional computers for Katrovian homes that already have computers, the new model's introduction is unlikely to increase the overall number of computers in Katrovian homes.

D. The assumption that other personal computer prices would stay relatively high does not help establish the link between its premises and its conclusion. If answer choice D were false, the argument would be no weaker than it is without any consideration of other computers' potential prices.

E. If most personal computers purchased in Katrovia were not intended for home use, then the new model's introduction would be even less likely to increase the number of personal computers in Katrovian homes. So, the argument does not depend on assuming that most of the computers purchased are for home use.

**The correct answer is C.**

•

Fast-food restaurants make up 45 percent of all restaurants in Canatria. Customers at these restaurants tend to be young; in fact, studies have shown that the older people get, the less likely they are to eat in fast-food restaurants. Since the average age of the Canatrian population is gradually rising and will continue to do so, the number of fast-food restaurants is likely to decrease.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously weakens the argument?

A. Fast-food restaurants in Canatria are getting bigger, so each one can serve more customers.

B. Some older people eat at fast-food restaurants more frequently than the average young person.

C. Many people who rarely eat in fast-food restaurants nevertheless eat regularly in restaurants.

D. The overall population of Canatria is growing steadily.

E. As the population of Canatria gets older, more people are eating at home.

**Argument Evaluation**

**Situation** In Canatria, the older people get, the less likely they are to eat in fast-food restaurants. The average age of Canatrians is increasing.

**Reasoning** *What evidence would most weaken the support provided by the cited facts for the prediction that the number of fast-food restaurants in Canatria is likely to decrease?* The argument implicitly reasons that since studies have shown that Canatrians tend to eat in fast-food restaurants less as they get older, and since Canatrians are getting older on average, the proportion of Canatrians eating in fast-food restaurants will decline. The argument assumes that this means the overall number of fast-food restaurant customers will decline and that demand will decrease enough to reduce the number of fast-food restaurants that can sustain profitability. Consequently, fewer new fast-food restaurants will open

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or more old ones will close, or both. Thus, the number of fast-food restaurants in Canatria will fall. Any evidence casting doubt on any inference in this chain of implicit reasoning will weaken the argument.

A. This strengthens the argument by providing additional evidence that the total number of fast-food restaurants will decrease. If the average number of customers per fast-food restaurant is increasing, then fewer fast-food restaurants will be needed to serve the same—or a lesser—number of customers.

B. Even if a few individuals do not follow the general trends described, those trends could still reduce the overall demand for and number of fast-food restaurants.

C. The argument is only about fast-food restaurants, not restaurants of other types.

D. **Correct.** This suggests that even if the proportion of Canatrians eating at fast-food restaurants declines, the total number doing so may not decline. Thus, the total demand for and profitability of fast-food restaurants may not decline either, so the total number of fast-food restaurants in Canatria may not decrease.

E. If anything, this strengthens the argument by pointing out an additional trend likely to reduce the demand for, and thus the number of, fast-food restaurants in Canatria.

**The correct answer is D.**

•

Last year a chain of fast-food restaurants, whose menu had always centered on hamburgers, added its first vegetarian sandwich, much lower in fat than the chain's other offerings. Despite heavy marketing, the new sandwich accounts for a very small proportion of the chain's sales. The sandwich's sales would have to quadruple to cover the costs associated with including it on the menu. Since such an increase is unlikely, the chain would be more profitable if it dropped the sandwich.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously weakens the argument?

A. Although many of the chain's customers have never tried the vegetarian sandwich, in a market research survey, most of those who had tried it reported that they were very satisfied with it.

B. Many of the people who eat at the chain's restaurants also eat at the restaurants of competing chains and report no strong preference among the competitors.

C. Among fast-food chains in general, there has been little or no growth in hamburger sales over the past several years as the range of competing offerings at other restaurants has grown.

D. When even one member of a group of diners is a vegetarian or has a preference for low-fat food, the group tends to avoid restaurants that lack vegetarian or low-fat menu options.

E. An attempt by the chain to introduce a lower-fat hamburger failed several years ago, since it attracted few new customers and most of the chain's regular customers greatly preferred the taste of the regular hamburgers.

**Argument Evaluation**

**Situation** Last year a fast-food restaurant chain specializing in hamburgers started offering a low-fat vegetarian sandwich and marketed it heavily. The new sandwich's sales are far too low to cover the costs associated with including it on the menu.

**Reasoning** *What evidence would most weaken the support provided by the cited facts for the prediction that it would be more profitable for the chain to drop the sandwich?* The implicit argument is that since the new sandwich's sales are too low to cover the costs associated with including it on the menu, offering the sandwich diminishes the chain's profitability and will continue to do so if the sandwich continues to be offered. This reasoning assumes that the sandwich provides the chain no substantial indirect financial benefits except through its direct sales. It also assumes that the sandwich's sales will not increase sufficiently to make the sandwich a viable product. Any evidence casting doubt on either of these assumptions will weaken the argument.

A. This gives information only about the respondents to the survey who had tried the sandwich (possibly very few), who were probably already more open to liking a vegetarian sandwich than any of the chain's other customers. So, their responses are probably unrepresentative of the chain's customers in general and do not suggest that the sandwich has enough market potential.

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sandwich has enough market potential.

B. Although the issue of competition with other restaurants is not raised in the information provided, this new information, if anything, strengthens the argument by suggesting that the introduction of the new sandwich has not significantly enhanced customer preference for eating at the restaurants that offer the new sandwich.

C. This suggests that the cause of stagnation in fast-food restaurants' hamburger sales has been competition from non-fast-food restaurants, but not that the non-fast-food restaurants competed by offering vegetarian options.

D. **Correct.** This suggests that even if the sandwich's sales are low, it may indirectly increase the chain's overall profits by encouraging large groups to eat at the chain.

E. This strengthens the argument by suggesting that the chain's customers are generally not interested in low-fat menu options such as the new sandwich.

**The correct answer is D.**

•

Transportation expenses accounted for a large portion of the total dollar amount spent on trips for pleasure by residents of the United States in 1997, and about half of the total dollar amount spent on transportation was for airfare. However, the large majority of United States residents who took trips for pleasure in 1997 did not travel by airplane but used other means of transportation.

If the statements above are true, which of the following must also be true about United States residents who took trips for pleasure in 1997?

A. Most of those who traveled by airplane did so because the airfare to their destination was lower than the cost of other available means of transportation.

B. Most of those who traveled by airplane did so because other means of transportation to their destination were unavailable.

C. Per mile traveled, those who traveled by airplane tended to spend more on transportation to their destination than did those who used other means of transportation.

D. Overall, people who did not travel by airplane had lower average transportation expenses than people who did.

E. Those who traveled by airplane spent about as much, on average, on other means of transportation as they did on airfare.

**Argument Construction**

**Situation** In 1997, about half of total transportation spending by U.S. residents taking trips for pleasure was for airfare. But the large majority of U.S. residents who took trips for pleasure in 1997 did not travel by airplane.

**Reasoning** *What can be deduced from the stated facts?* The information provided indicates that among U.S. residents who took trips for pleasure in 1997, those who traveled by airplane were a small minority. Yet this small minority's spending for airfare accounted for half of all transportation spending among residents taking trips for pleasure. It follows that on average, those who traveled by airplane must have spent far more per person on transportation than those who did not travel by airplane.

A. This does not follow logically from the information given. Most of those who traveled by airplane may have done so even if flying was more expensive than other modes of transportation—for example, because flying was faster or more comfortable.

B. This does not follow from the information given. Most of those who traveled by airplane may have done so even if many other modes of transportation were available—the other modes may all have been less desirable.

C. This does not follow from the information given. Those who traveled by airplane may have traveled much farther on average than those who used other means of transportation, so their transportation spending per mile traveled need not have been greater.

D. **Correct.** As explained above, those who traveled by airplane must have spent more per person on transportation than those who did not travel by airplane, on average. In other words, those who did not travel by airplane must have had lower average transportation expenses than those who did.

E. This does not follow from the information given. Although half the total dollar spending on transportation was

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E. This does not follow from the information given. Although half the total dollar spending on transportation was for airfare, much of the transportation spending that was not for airfare was by the large majority of U.S. residents who did not travel by airplane.

**The correct answer is D.**

•

Voters commonly condemn politicians for being insincere, but politicians often must disguise their true feelings when they make public statements. If they expressed their honest views—about, say, their party's policies—then achieving politically necessary compromises would be much more difficult. Clearly, the very insincerity that people decry shows that our government is functioning well.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously undermines this reasoning?

A. Achieving political compromises is not all that is necessary for the proper functioning of a government.

B. Some political compromises are not in the best long-term interest of the government.

C. Voters often judge politicians by criteria other than the sincerity with which they express their views.

D. A political party's policies could turn out to be detrimental to the functioning of a government.

E. Some of the public statements made by politicians about their party's policies could in fact be sincere.

**Argument Evaluation**

**Situation** Politicians must often make insincere public statements because expressing their true feelings would make it harder for them to achieve politically necessary compromises.

**Reasoning** *What would suggest that the argument's premises do not establish that politicians' insincerity shows our government is functioning well?* The implicit reasoning is that insincerity helps politicians achieve politically necessary compromises, and these compromises help our government to function well, so insincerity must show that our government is functioning well. Evidence that these necessary compromises do not ensure that our government functions well would undermine the argument's reasoning, as would evidence that politicians' insincerity has other substantial effects that hinder the government's functioning.

A. **Correct.** If governments may function poorly even when insincerity allows necessary political compromises to be made, then the argument's premises do not establish that politicians' insincerity shows our government is functioning well.

B. The argument does not require that all political compromises help government to function well, only that politically necessary compromises do.

C. Even if voters often judge politicians by criteria other than their sincerity, they may also often decry politicians' insincerity, not realizing or caring that such insincerity helps the government function well.

D. Even if a political party's policies impair the government's functioning, politically necessary compromises by politicians in that party could improve the government's functioning.

E. Even if politicians sometimes speak sincerely about their party's policies, their general willingness to be insincere as needed to achieve politically necessary compromises could be a sign that the government is functioning well.

**The correct answer is A.**

•

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